product of the British and socialist eras. However, it is now being swamped by those climbing into the middle class from the slums and small ‘mofussil’ towns. Unlike the incumbents, the newcomers are usually the first generation that can speak some English. Their parents would have been the first literate generation and their grandparents would often have been illiterate subsistence farmers. One sees them working in call-centres or as shop-assistants in the malls. Even the changing social background of India’s sports heroes hints at the shift. India has never witnessed such social mobility.

Moreover, as the new middle class climbs the social ladder, its tastes and attitudes will impact the mainstream. This is already visible from Bollywood music to television news. The superhit Bollywood song *Munni Badnaam Hui* (Munni is Notorious) is an example of how ‘mofussil’ music is being mainstreamed. No matter what the snobs of the old middle class may say, this is generally a good thing.

DIASPORA—BEING INDIAN IN THE TWENTY-FIRST CENTURY

As we have seen in the previous chapter, Indians had again begun to travel and migrate abroad during the colonial era. The fortunes of these various diasporas changed with the withdrawal of British rule. In some places like Singapore and Mauritius, the Indian community would thrive. However, in many places, they faced severe persecution. In 1962, the Indian community in Burma was expelled by the dictator Ne Win and its properties were expropriated. A similar fate befell the Gujarati community in Uganda under Idi Amin in 1972. Some of these groups returned to India but others sailed farther afield. The Ugandan Gujaratis, for instance, moved to Britain in large numbers and would become a successful business community.

After independence, the nature of Indian migrations changed. There was one wave in the ’50s and the ’60s, with Punjabis moving to the United Kingdom as industrial workers. Another was of Anglo-Indians who migrated to Australia and Canada. By the 1970s, the oil-rich Arab states in the Persian Gulf began to import Indians in large numbers to work in